Himalayan watershed and enter Indian territory, lightly equipped mobile commandos should be used to harass their lines of communication and the Indian Army should stay away from a conventional conflict. Only once the Chinese had entered the plains was the army to ‘take advantage of our superior fire power to defeat them’. By this time, Nehru too had begun to realize that sooner or later there would be a clash between the two countries. However, from the various records available from that period, it seemed that the government was expecting only border clashes to take place that were unlikely to escalate further.

By the mid-1950s, over 200,000 PLA troops were stationed in Tibet, resulting in famine conditions as the country’s delicate subsistence agricultural system was stretched beyond capacity. Ironically, the Panchsheel Treaty allowed the Chinese to import rice from India to tide over the problem.

By February 1956, a revolt had broken out in parts of Kham and Amdo in Eastern Tibet as local guerrilla forces took on the Chinese troops. The PLA responded by bombing and pillaging monasteries, arresting nobles, senior monks and guerrilla leaders and publicly torturing and executing them to discourage the large-scale resistance they were facing. As refugees from the Kham region began to pour into Lhasa, the Tibetans became increasingly agitated and non-violent resistance increased. Posters denouncing the occupation went up. Stones and dried yak dung were hurled at Chinese street parades. During this period, the directive from Peking was still to woo the Tibetans in Lhasa.

However, the situation continued to worsen, and by December 1958, a revolt was simmering and the Chinese military command was threatening to bomb Lhasa and the Dalai Lama’s palace if the unrest was not contained. In March of 1959, the Tibetans feared that the Chinese were planning to abduct the Dalai Lama and take him to Beijing to attend the upcoming Chinese National Assembly. Five thousand Tibetan women marched to the Indian Consulate in Lhasa and presented an appeal for help, while carrying banners demanding ‘Tibet for Tibetans’ and shouting ‘From today Tibet is independent’. As Chinese troops positioned sandbag fortifications for machine guns on the city’s flat rooftops and wheeled in heavy guns, the Dalai Lama, wearing a soldier’s uniform and with a gun slung over his shoulder, finally slipped out of the city on 17 March and arrived a few days